

# Turn Ads Into *Customers*

*Build a local Meta engine that meets strangers with something free, follows the ones who didn't buy, and keeps your own customers close, without burning budget on people who already know you.*

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WHY THIS PLAYBOOK EXISTS

# A strong ad is not the game. The order is.

*Paid ads work when you match the message to how warm the person already is, so you build for three stages and let each one carry its own job.*

My wife was shooting new looks every week for [terrelldominick.com](http://terrelldominick.com), so we took 45 of them, sorted them into categories, and turned the whole thing into a free download. We ran it cold on Meta to women who had never heard of the brand, carved out everyone who already knew us so the budget only chased strangers, and set the objective to leads instead of sales to keep the clicks cheap. That book pulled in 3,789 new emails and phone numbers, a discount code at the end brought in enough orders to basically cover the spend, and the campaign turned \$4,634 into \$10,408. A separate ad for our best-selling Balloon Top came back over 6x.

What moved the numbers was the order we put things in. We met strangers with something free, followed the ones who hadn't bought with a reason to act, and kept the people who had already bought close with no discount. That same ladder fills a calendar in your town the way it sells clothes online, and it is the entire job of your local digital engine.

## THE ENGINE, TOP TO BOTTOM

- **Top of funnel (TOF).** Strangers who have never heard of you. Lead with something free, set the objective to leads, and grow the pie.
- **Middle of funnel (MOF).** People who looked, engaged, and didn't buy. Put a reason to act back in front of them. Usually the easiest win.
- **Bottom of funnel (BOF).** Your own customers. Retarget your list on a short window, drop the discount, and speak to the bigger why.

This playbook turns that engine into the build. Work the pages top to bottom and you will have the foundation, the audiences, the local targeting, the three ads, and the one number to watch ready to run.

# The few words that run the whole thing.

*You do not need the jargon to run good ads. These are the handful of terms Meta puts in front of you, in plain language.*

## TOF, MOF, BOF

Top, middle, and bottom of funnel. Strangers, people who engaged and didn't buy, and your own customers.

## The pixel

A snippet of code on your site that tells Meta who visited what. Without it, retargeting and tracking simply cannot fire.

## Events

The actions the pixel watches for, a page view, a lead, a purchase, so Meta knows what counts as a win.

## Retargeting

Showing an ad to people who already touched your business, your visitors, your list, or your engagers.

## Custom audience

A list you build from your own data, like website visitors or your customer file, for Meta to target or exclude.

## Lookalike audience

Meta finds new strangers who resemble one of your custom audiences. A warmer way to reach cold people.

## Step 1 • Lay the foundation

Nothing below works until the pixel is on your site and firing. This is the plumbing, so do it once and do it right.

### THE FOUNDATION, IN ORDER

- **Install the pixel.** In Meta Events Manager, click Connect Data Sources, choose Web, and follow the install for your site builder or hand the snippet to whoever manages it.
- **Turn on a few key events.** At a minimum, track PageView, Lead, and Purchase, so Meta can optimize toward the action that actually matters to you.
- **Point every ad at one offer or booking page.** A single clean page with one action, claim the offer or book the time, so the pixel has one clear win to record.

Meta moves these buttons around more than any of us would like, so if a path reads differently on your screen, look for the same words.

STEP 2 • BUILD YOUR AUDIENCES

# Your audiences do the targeting for you.

*Build these four once and the rest of the engine has something to fire on. You make them in Audiences inside Meta Ads Manager, under Create Audience.*

## THE FOUR TO BUILD

- **Website visitors.** A custom audience of everyone the pixel has seen on your site, usually a 30 to 180 day window. This is your warm middle.
- **Your customer list.** Upload the emails and phone numbers of people who have already paid you. This becomes your bottom-of-funnel audience and the seed for lookalikes.
- **Engagers.** People who followed your page, liked, commented, watched a video, or opened a form. Build these from your Facebook and Instagram accounts as the source.
- **Lookalikes.** Ask Meta to find new strangers who resemble your customer list. The warmest way to reach cold people, since it starts from your best buyers.

## The exclusion that saves your budget

The easiest way to burn money is letting repeat customers who already know, like, and trust you cash in on a new-customer-only discount, just because you didn't target correctly. When you run a top-of-funnel ad meant for strangers, exclude your website visitors, your customer list, and your engagers, so the cold budget only ever chases cold people. That one exclusion is the difference between growing the pie and paying to discount the customers you already had.

Local audiences are small, so keep exclusions light. Carve out your known people on cold ads, then stop. Heavy stacked exclusions that work for a national ecommerce brand will starve a local audience down to nothing.

STEP 3 · TARGET YOUR TOWN

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# Lead with location, keep the rest broad.

*A local business wins on geography first. Drop a pin on your shop, set a radius that fits your market, and let the offer do the sorting.*

## **Set the radius to your market** · not a national default

In a dense city like Jersey City, 3 to 5 miles is plenty. Across most of the country, 5 to 10 miles fits the way people actually drive to you. Use a pin and radius around your location, or enter the specific zip codes you serve when your area is shaped oddly.

## **Keep the rest of the targeting broad** · let creative sort

Resist stacking interests and behaviors on top of a small local radius. The geography is doing the heavy lifting, and the creative, the free guide or the first-visit offer, sorts the right people in. Narrow targeting on a small town just raises your costs.

## **Match the objective to the action** · conversions almost every time

Set the objective to conversions, then pick the event you want. A lead is the cheaper conversion to chase and a purchase costs more, so at the top you optimize for leads. Traffic or engagement is only worth running as a small budgeted test, never the main job.

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## **The one number to watch**

You do not need a dashboard. You need to know what one new customer is worth to you and what you are paying to get one. If a customer is worth more than the ad spent to land them, the engine works and you feed it. If it is not, you fix the offer or the targeting before you spend another dollar.

STEP 4 · RUN THE THREE ADS

# One ad per stage, each with its own job.

*Most people run a single ad to everyone. The move is to run three, matched to how warm the person is, with a small budget to start each one.*

## **Top of funnel · grow the pie** · cold strangers

Target by location, exclude your known people, and lead with something free or low-risk, a guide, a checklist, or a first-visit offer. Optimize for leads so the clicks stay cheap, and let the creative sell the outcome they actually want.

**BUDGET TO START · \$5 TO \$10 A DAY, LEAVE IT ALONE FOR A FEW DAYS**

## **Middle of funnel · win them back** · looked, engaged, didn't buy

Target your website visitors and engagers, and put a reason to act in front of them, a limited offer or the next piece of the teaching. This is the stage most people skip and the easiest to win, because these people already know you and just need a reason to come back.

**BUDGET TO START · \$5 A DAY, THIS AUDIENCE IS SMALL AND WARM**

## **Bottom of funnel · keep them close** · your own customers

Target your customer list and put your offers back in front of people who have already paid you. Drop the discount, since they already trust you, and run it as retargeting on a short window, around 60 days, so the spend stays on customers while their last visit is fresh.

**BUDGET TO START · \$5 A DAY ON A 60-DAY WINDOW**

Where the message grows up. Up top you lead with the practical reason to buy and a deal to get a stranger over the hump. With your own customers you can speak to the bigger why, the ease it gives them, the pride they feel, the way it changes their day, and the standing it earns them with the people they care about.

STEP 4 · SWIPE COPY FOR EACH STAGE

# Lift these, swap your details, run them.

*Adapt each to your town, your offer, and your number, and keep every promise honest.*

## TOP OF FUNNEL · COLD

Local [city] [who they are], grab this free [guide or offer]. It shows you [outcome] without [the thing they dread]. Tap to get it, no cost, takes a minute.

## MIDDLE OF FUNNEL · LOOKED, DIDN'T BUY

Still thinking it over? For the next [number] days, [limited offer] is open to [city] locals. You already saw what we do. This is the nudge to come in. Claim it here: [link]

## BOTTOM OF FUNNEL · YOUR CUSTOMERS

[First name], we just [new thing, new colorist, new look, new service]. You already know how this goes. Want me to hold you a spot this week? Book here: [link]

## The profile is the trust layer

Your ad sends people two places, your offer and your profile. A good chunk of locals will tap your Instagram or Facebook before they ever click the offer, just to see if you are real, active, and serving people like them. If your last post is from eight months ago, the ad money leaks right there. When I ran JCF, our social was all community and results, the faces and the before-and-afters, because people will quit a gym long before they quit the friends they made inside it. Keep your profile alive with recent work and real results so the curious click lands somewhere that closes the sale instead of raising a doubt.

One honest note on Google. Run Meta for the paid work, and let the Google Business Profile you tightened up in Part 3 carry search, free, in front of people already looking for what you do.

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE IN YOUR WORLD · THEN BUILD IT

# Four businesses, one ladder.

Same engine, different offer at each stage. Find the row closest to yours and copy the moves.

| BUSINESS TYPE        | HOW THE LADDER RUNS                                                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Home Service         | A plumber runs a cold ad to a lead magnet, 5 Signs Your Water Heater Is About to Fail, and the thank-you page hands over a self-booking calendar so the warmest ones book on the spot.     |
| Restaurant / Retail  | A boutique targets women with birthdays this month inside its zip codes, invites them in for a styling visit and a gift, and a set capacity captures a name, phone, and email to book.     |
| Personal Service     | A studio runs a free six-week challenge to cold locals, retargets the no-shows with "three spots left this week," and a salon puts its new colorist back in front of past clients.         |
| Professional Service | An advisor runs a plain-language info-session ad to lower the guard people bring to a first call, then retargets attendees into a booked consult. Education is home turf, the easiest win. |

## Build it this week

- 1

**Doer**  
Install the pixel and turn on one location-targeted ad to a single free offer. Start at \$5 to \$10 a day and leave it alone for a few days before you touch it.
- 2

**Manager**  
Build your four audiences, website visitors, customer list, engagers, and a lookalike, so your retargeting has something to fire on this week.
- 3

**Owner CEO**  
Map the full ladder, set the one offer at each stage, and set the budget rule, start small, check the outcome, and raise no more than 20% every 3 to 4 days.

The ad gets attention, the ladder turns it into customers, and your profile is the proof that makes the click worth it. Build it in that order and the money stops leaking out the sides.